

CONCORD PARENT PROMOTION GUIDE

Growing Up in Grace

A Parent's Milestone, Screen, & Grade Transition Guide

"Train up a child in the way he should go; even when he is old he will not depart from it."

PROVERBS 22:6

THE FIVE PHASES

1**Early Childhood****AGES 3-4½**

Entering Preschool / Pre-K

The Commander**2****Middle Childhood****AGES 5-7**

Entering Kindergarten - 2nd Grade

The Coach**3****Pre-Adolescence****AGES 8-10**

Entering 3rd - 5th Grade / Upper Elementary

The Coach**4****Early Adolescence****AGES 11-12**

Entering 6th - 7th Grade / Middle School

The Counselor**5****High School &
Adulthood****AGES 13-18+**

Entering 9th Grade / High School & Beyond

The Consultant



PHASE ONE | PRESCHOOL / PRE-K

Early Childhood

AGES 3-4½

A practical guide for this big season of growth.



YOUR POSTURE THIS SEASON

The Commander. Loving, steady authority providing a safe perimeter of routines.

THIS SEASON

A season of explosive imagination and rapid neurological growth where children explore boundaries and struggle with logic. Parents must act as protective authorities, pointing wild imaginations toward the security of God's truth and protecting their minds from digital passive consumption.

DEVELOPMENTAL MILESTONES

01 NEUROLOGICAL

Brain is 2.5 times more active than an adult brain; struggles with logic and perspective-taking.

02 PHYSICAL

Rides tricycles; dresses and feeds self with help; undergoes a temporary neurological "wobble" wave of clumsiness or minor stuttering at 3½.

03 SOCIAL & EMOTIONAL

Speaks in complete sentences; experiences intense emotions; plays make-believe but naturally struggles heavily with sharing or cooperative play.

HOW TO PARENT THIS SEASON

1

Keep Rules Simple: Use brief, 1-to-3 step directions. Use limited, two-option choices to build confidence without overwhelming them.

2

Gently Correct "Fantastical Lies": When they blur fact and fiction, don't panic or treat them like a criminal offense. Parent out of love rather than fear, saying: "That is a fun make-believe story, but now let's tell a true story together because God loves the truth."

3

Comfort Fears with Presence: At 4½, when night terrors or phobias peak, do not try to reason or lecture them out of it. Sit with them, pray aloud, and remind them that "God has not given us a spirit of fear, but of power, love, and a sound mind" (2 Timothy 1:7).

SCREEN CONSIDERATIONS

THE RULE

Strictly Limited & Contextualized.

Under age 6, non-educational screen time should be restricted to less than 1 hour per weekday.

The Action: Never use devices as emotional regulators or “pacifiers” for tantrums. All devices must be strictly barred from bedrooms. Keep their attention anchored on physical, play-based reality, allowing them to explore God’s physical creation over virtual alternatives.

GRADE TRANSITION DYNAMICS

THE SHIFT

Moving from the insular safety of home or childcare into structured classroom spaces.

WHAT TO WATCH FOR

Expect separation anxiety and physical exhaustion. They will likely collapse into tantrums after school because they used all their emotional energy to hold it together in class.

PARENTING ACTION

Create a predictable “goodbye ritual” for school drop-offs and stick to it. Do not linger, as lingering fuels their anxiety; trust that teachers will help them transition once you step away.

WHEN TO SEEK SUPPORT

Extreme Separation Anxiety: Completely withdrawing from friends and play.

Behavioral Regressions: Severe behavioral regressions or intense, prolonged toilet-training failures.

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A RESOURCE FOR CONCORD FAMILIES

This guide is brought to you through our intentional partnership with Peak Wellness Centers, PLLC. Located directly on the campus of First Baptist Concord and Concord Christian School, Peak provides seamlessly integrated, clinically excellent, and spiritually aligned care for our families. Visit our resource table in the lobby.

BUILT ON

Dr. Dee C. Ray, *A Therapist’s Guide to Child Development* (2016) | Focus on the Family, *The Four Phases of Parenthood* | Daystar Counseling Ministries, *Are My Kids on Track?* and *Wild Things* | Dr. Jonathan Haidt, *The Anxious Generation* (2024)



PHASE TWO | KINDERGARTEN - 2ND GRADE

Middle Childhood

AGES 5-7

Helping children grow in resilience, honesty, and grace.

YOUR POSTURE THIS SEASON

The Coach. Standing on the sidelines to guide, encourage, and prompt independent effort.

THIS SEASON

As children enter formal school environments, they transition from pleasing adults to testing boundaries and battling perfectionism. Parents step to the sidelines to coach them through the spiritual milestones of resilience, honesty, and grace under pressure.

DEVELOPMENTAL MILESTONES

01 NEUROLOGICAL

Brain integration peaks; attention span grows to 20-30 minutes; transitions from logical ease at 5 to intense boundary-testing at 5½.

02 PHYSICAL

Starts losing baby teeth; prints first and last name; rides a bicycle without training wheels.

03 SOCIAL & EMOTIONAL

Highly sensitive to criticism; experiences intense performance anxiety or perfectionism; intensely competitive (the "poor sport" phase).

HOW TO PARENT THIS SEASON

- 1 Coaching Through Defeat:** At 6, when they cheat or pout to win games, use it as a training playground. Resist the urge to fix or rescue them from the discomfort of losing. Say: "It's okay to feel sad that you lost, but in this family, we honor God by playing honestly and celebrating others."
- 2 Give Contributing Household Roles:** Keep them grounded by establishing daily chores (like clearing plates). This feeds their structural need for competence and teaches biblical stewardship.
- 3 Soothe the "Age 7 Melancholy":** When your 7-year-old turns inward, displays perfectionism, or carries heavy worries, recognize it as a milestone of growing emotional awareness. Ask open-ended questions rather than lecturing: "What is a big thought you've been carrying in your heart today? Let's give it to Jesus in prayer together."

SCREEN CONSIDERATIONS

THE RULE

Entertainment Caps & Content Control.

Entertainment screen time should be restricted to a firm maximum of 2 hours daily.

The Action: Enforce device-free dinner tables and strictly device-free bedrooms and bathrooms. Children require physical “anti-fragility” training, meaning they must learn to resolve social conflicts, navigate boredom, and process failure in face-to-face play rather than escaping into digital spaces.

GRADE TRANSITION DYNAMICS

THE SHIFT

Moving into rigid academic routines, desk time, grades, and a broader peer landscape.

WHAT TO WATCH FOR

The age 5½ to 6 transition brings boundary-testing against new school rules, while age 7 brings deep academic perfectionism (erasing work repeatedly to meet impossibly high standards).

PARENTING ACTION

Celebrate effort and character over grades. When they bring home schoolwork, say: “I see how hard you tried on this math page! God loves when we use our minds to do our best, and I am so proud of your determination.”

WHEN TO SEEK SUPPORT

Aggressive Behavior: The child displays highly aggressive behavior toward parents, teachers, or peers.

Paralyzing Perfectionism: Extreme perfectionism or phobias that paralyze them from completing daily tasks or trying new skills.

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PHASE THREE | 3RD - 5TH GRADE

Pre-Adolescence

AGES 8-10

*Protect connection. Coach friendship.
Anchor identity in Christ.*



YOUR POSTURE THIS SEASON

The Coach. Shifting from micromanagement to protecting your relational connection.

THIS SEASON

The focal point of the child's world begins a massive structural shift away from parents and toward peer groups. Parents must protect their relational equity, coaching their pre-teens to anchor their capabilities and identities securely in Christ rather than the opinions of friends.

DEVELOPMENTAL MILESTONES

01 NEUROLOGICAL

Processing speed increases; abstract thinking begins to form; highly detail-oriented and organized.

02 PHYSICAL

Peaks in physical activity levels and energy; rapid growth spurts begin for girls (boys often lag behind physically here).

03 SOCIAL & EMOTIONAL

Deeply influenced by peer pressure; highly critical of self and others; tends to hide internal anxieties from adults.

HOW TO PARENT THIS SEASON

1

Implement the 30-Minute Connection Rule: To combat the natural peer pull, secure 30 minutes of weekly, dedicated one-on-one time where they pick the activity.

2

Address Anxiety Somatically: When 9-year-olds face performance stress, recognize that their anxiety often manifests physically as stomach aches or headaches. Help them regulate emotionally, teaching them physical and spiritual grounding techniques like taking deep breaths and quoting scripture.

3

Proactive Social Coaching: Take advantage of the age 10 window where they are uniquely open to adult feedback on social issues. Discuss friendship intentionally: "What makes someone a true, encouraging friend? How can you show Christ's kindness to kids who are being left out?"

SCREEN CONSIDERATIONS

THE RULE

No Personal Smartphones.

Stick strictly to basic phone alternatives (dumbphones, flip phones, or smartwatches with text and call-only capabilities) if communication is required.

The Action: Parents must collectively stand against the “network effect,” the fear that your child will be left out socially if they don’t have a smartphone. Giving an internet-connected smartphone during this window halts real-world social mastery and dramatically spikes early onset anxiety as social dynamics intensify.

GRADE TRANSITION DYNAMICS

THE SHIFT

Transitioning to departmentalized classes (switching rooms and teachers), standardized testing, and heavier workloads.

WHAT TO WATCH FOR

Test anxiety and a sudden fear of academic failure peak sharply in 4th and 5th grade. They may start faking illness or avoiding situations where they believe they might fail.

PARENTING ACTION

Affirm their identity separate from performance. Remind them: “A test grade only measures what you know on one day; it does not measure your worth to us or your value to God.”

WHEN TO SEEK SUPPORT

Chronic Somatic Complaints: Stomach aches or insomnia become chronic and interfere with daily school or church attendance.

Collapse of Capability: The child completely withdraws from friends, sports, and hobbies out of an overwhelming fear of failure.

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PHASE FOUR | 6TH - 7TH GRADE

Early Adolescence

AGES 11-12

Listen first. Guide with wisdom. Correct with dignity.

YOUR POSTURE THIS SEASON

The Counselor. Trading lectures and top-down control for active listening and guiding wisdom.

THIS SEASON

The volatile onset of puberty triggers erratic moods, a fierce drive for independence, and a constant questioning of structural authority. Parents must transition into a counselor role, prioritizing relationship preservation and private correction to protect their fragile dignity.

DEVELOPMENTAL MILESTONES

01 NEUROLOGICAL

Heavy prefrontal cortex remodeling; abstract thinking expands, but limited executive functioning causes impulsive actions.

02 PHYSICAL

Onset of puberty and physical maturation; sleep patterns shift naturally (wanting to stay up later and sleep in later).

03 SOCIAL & EMOTIONAL

Highly unpredictable, moody, and easily frustrated; primary emotional support shifts almost entirely to peers; actively challenges rules.

HOW TO PARENT THIS SEASON

- 1 Never Correct in Public:** Due to their massive social self-consciousness and pride, public discipline will breed deep resentment. Wait until you are privately in the car or at home to address disrespect or behavioral issues.
- 2 Trade Lectures for Guided Choices:** Do not parent a pre-teen the way you parented a toddler. Shift your language to invite autonomy: "That is a decision you are old enough to make. What do you think the potential outcomes or consequences will be?"
- 3 Listen and Don't "Fix":** When they bring home middle school drama, or question aspects of life and faith, just listen. Avoid the temptation to immediately step in and solve the issue; they need a safe, steady processing partner, not an immediate judge.

SCREEN CONSIDERATIONS

THE RULE

No Social Media Before Age 16.

Keep all algorithms of social comparison entirely away from early adolescents.

The Action: Early puberty is the absolute most vulnerable window of brain development. Research demonstrates a devastating correlation between early social media use and a spike in depression, particularly via social comparison for girls and digital withdrawal (video game or pornography fixation) for boys. Keep the school day completely phone-free (“bell-to-bell”), and require all electronics to be placed in a central household charging station at night.

GRADE TRANSITION DYNAMICS

THE SHIFT

The massive leap into Middle School, navigating lockers, multiple teachers, complex social hierarchies, and shifting friend groups.

WHAT TO WATCH FOR

Academic motivation often tanks if they do not find a subject immediately interesting. They are highly prone to experiencing clique dynamics or bullying as they try to mold their personality to fit in.

PARENTING ACTION

Expect the academic wobble. Use their planner or digital school portal to help them audit their assignments with them as a counselor, rather than taking over the work or yelling at them about missed deadlines.

WHEN TO SEEK SUPPORT

Severe Obedience Failures: Destructive behavior, or signs of digital bullying or exclusion.

Chronic Disconnection: If you, as a parent, feel chronically disconnected, operating entirely out of fear, anger, or despair in the relationship.

Call us at **865.643.8838**. For urgent concerns at any hour, call or text **988**, the Suicide and Crisis Lifeline.

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PHASE FIVE | 9TH GRADE & BEYOND

High School & Adulthood

AGES 13-18+

Release control. Remain available. Trust what you have built.



YOUR POSTURE THIS SEASON

The Consultant. Moving from direct authority to an on-call advisor, respecting their growing independence.

THIS SEASON

As teenagers navigate high school and cross the threshold of graduation, they are actively evaluating if the faith they grew up with is truly their own. Parents must occupy the passenger seat as consultants, releasing control and trusting the Holy Spirit as they launch their young adults into the world.

DEVELOPMENTAL MILESTONES

01 NEUROLOGICAL

Prefrontal cortex optimization continues; abstract, hypothetical reasoning peaks; capable of deep theological and ethical evaluation.

02 PHYSICAL

Physical maturity is fully reached; experiences significant fatigue and stress related to heavy performance pressures.

03 SOCIAL & EMOTIONAL

Establishes a distinct adult identity; actively pulls away from family to prioritize autonomy; future-oriented anxiety climbs.

HOW TO PARENT THIS SEASON

- 1 Adopt the Consultant Mantra:** Shift your baseline posture to an advisor. Use the phrasing: "I am always here for you. Let me know if I can help or offer some advice as you think through this."
- 2 Prioritize Practice over Rescue:** Avoid a "crisis of capability" caused by doing tasks for high schoolers that they can do themselves. Let them wake themselves up, manage their own school schedules, and communicate directly with authority figures. When they face setbacks, remind them: "You are entirely capable of handling this hard thing. What do you think your next steps should be?"
- 3 Welcome Spiritual Questions:** If your teen voices doubts about God or the church, don't respond with defensive anger. A faith that is never wrestled with is rarely a faith that survives outside the home; guide them toward scripture and historical Christian apologetics with gentleness, patience, and respect.

SCREEN CONSIDERATIONS

THE RULE

Graduated Autonomy & Digital Discipleship.

Introduce social media and full smartphone access gradually during high school, focused entirely on agency and self-control.

The Action: Sit down together and mutually establish a digital “time budget” using built-in screen time tracking features. Rather than imposing top-down authoritarian bans, use this phase to mentor them in self-regulation. If they experience toxic digital habits, coach them on taking intentional digital fasts, reminding them that their primary worth is derived as an image-bearer of God (Imago Dei), completely disconnected from online curation, views, or metrics.

GRADE TRANSITION DYNAMICS

THE SHIFT

Entering the high school transcript era where GPA, college preparation, jobs, driving, and romantic relationships shape daily reality, culminating in the final transition out of the home upon graduation.

WHAT TO WATCH FOR

Chronic burnout and exhaustion from over-scheduling. The pressure to build a resume or fit into modern cultural templates can leave them operating out of a performance-based identity.

PARENTING ACTION

Intentionally schedule down-time. Protect family sabbaths where schoolwork and screens are set aside to rest in God’s grace, teaching them that their identity is anchored in their adoption as a child of God, not their performance.

WHEN TO SEEK SUPPORT

Severe Prolonged Depression: Self-isolation, or paralyzing future anxiety.

Complete Checkout: Complete spiritual or emotional check-out paired with destructive substance abuse or reckless behaviors.

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